Most Improved Big State: Himachal Pradesh

Led by former chief minister Jairam Thakur, the hill state equipped all government hospitals with oxygen supply and was the first to achieve 100 per cent vaccination while battling Covid-19. With a total health outlay of Rs 3,185 crore in 2021-22, the expenditure per person has almost doubled in four years from Rs 2,765 in 2017-18. Just before the assembly election, PM Narendra Modi inaugurated an AIIMS in Bilaspur. The state also has its own health insurance scheme, HIMCARE, to provide universal coverage to its citizens. Under new CM Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu, the state will have to build roads to connect remote areas and set up healthcare facilities closer to the habitats to provide timely medical intervention.

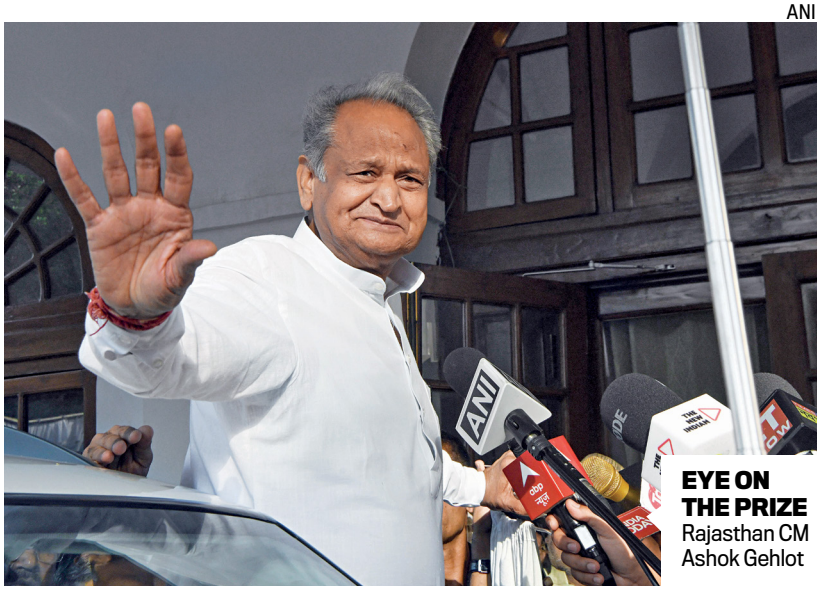
Most Improved Small State: Mizoram

As the year drew to an end, a small piece of news brought cheers to the state of Mizoram—nine Mizo nurses were among the 50 selected from India to work as 'specified skills workers' in Japan, which is facing severe labour shortage, as part of a pact between the two countries. The fact that nearly a fifth of the nurses selected were from Mizoram, which accounts for just 0.00082 per cent of India's population, reflects the high standard of healthcare facilities in the state. The reason is the successive state governments' focus on healthcare spending—the expenditure on health per person in 2021-22 was Rs 5,862. The state also showed a massive drop in IMR, registering only three deaths per 1,000 live births in 2019, down from 32 in 2015. ■

–Jeemon Jacob, Amarnath K. Menon, Anilesh S. Mahajan and Kaushik Deka

CATEGORY WINNERS **EDUCATION**

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EYE ON THE PRIZE
Rajasthan CM Ashok Gehlot

FRONTBENCHERS

Rajasthan and Meghalaya emerge as the most improved states in the field of education even as Himachal Pradesh and Goa continue to deliver the best performance



Among the first to achieve universal enrolment till Class 8, Himachal Pradesh has retained the top position on the list of best performing big states in education. Goa has bagged the laurels among small states. The parameters for evaluation included the expenditure on education, pupil-teacher ratio, dropout rate, and number of institutions—schools, colleges and universities.

Best Performing Big State: Himachal Pradesh

The former BJP regime had consistently dedicated almost 16 per cent of the state budget towards education. As many as 15 Atal Adarsh Vidya Kendras, where free education and hostel facilities are provided, have come up. All government schools have been equipped with